PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Wrangler YJ

1987–1995 · YJ

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame, spring hangers and floors first**
  Quadratec's inspection checklist names the rear leaf-spring mounts, frame rails, skid-plate mounts, rear crossmember, driver-side floor and roll-bar mounts. Lift the carpet: it warns that moisture trapped under old padding rots YJ floor pans from the top down.

- [ ] **Does 4WD actually engage?**
  The front axle is engaged by a vacuum motor. If the 4WD light stays off, or 4WD feels inconsistent, suspect dry-rotted, cracked or disconnected vacuum lines. Many owners convert to a cable-operated disconnect.

- [ ] **Clutch slave cylinder (early YJs)**
  Early manual YJs use an internal slave cylinder built into the release bearing. 4WD Mechanix dates it to 1987–92 with an external slave from 1993; Wikipedia says the slave moved outside the bellhousing for 1994, and Advance Adapters sells its internal-bearing hose kit for 1987–93. When the internal slave leaks, fluid can ruin the clutch disc, and replacing it means pulling the transmission. Look for fluid weeping from the bellhousing and a sinking pedal, and check whether the slave is visible on the outside of the bellhousing.

- [ ] **Know the gearbox and transfer case**
  Six-cylinder trucks from 1987–89 may have the Peugeot BA-10/5, which ExtremeTerrain calls historically unreliable. A 1987 may also have the NP207 transfer case. An AX-15 and NP231 combination is what most buyers want.

- [ ] **Carbureted 4.2 or injected 4.0?**
  The 1987–90 4.2 uses a computer-controlled Carter BBD with a maze of vacuum lines that are prone to leaks. It can be made reliable, but the 1991–95 4.0 is the engine Hagerty says commands the premium.

- [ ] **Leaf springs, shackles and bushings**
  Check for sagging or broken leaves, cracked bushings, rusted shackles and uneven ride height. Most YJs are more than 30 years old, so tired springs are normal and fresh ones change the ride.

- [ ] **Electrical grounds**
  Flickering lights, jumping gauges and intermittent starting often come from bad grounds. Quadratec suggests cleaning the firewall ground straps and battery connections before chasing anything bigger.

- [ ] **The rear axle**
  Most YJs have the Dana 35 rear. Drivingline calls the same axle in the TJ 'junk' because of its C-clip design, so if you plan bigger tires, price in a Dana 44 swap or upgraded shafts. A factory Dana 44 is worth looking for.

YEARS TO KNOW

1991	SWEET SPOT	Fuel-injected 4.0 L six replaces the carbureted 4.2; Hagerty says the 4.0 sixes are often the most desirable YJs. Renegade Decor Group arrives (built from October 1990)
1994	SWEET SPOT	Automatic offered with the four; center high-mounted stop lamp. Manual trucks get an external clutch slave cylinder (Wikipedia; 4WD Mechanix says 1993), which is why SlashGear calls 1994–95 the best YJ years: no pulling the gearbox to replace the slave

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Lug nuts and steering-shaft clamp bolts not tightened**
  1987 · NHTSA 86V058000
- ☐ **Windshield frame cracks at wiper pivots**
  1987–1988 · NHTSA 88V155000
- ☐ **Front brake hoses rub on splash shields**
  1987–1992 · NHTSA 92V148000
- ☐ **Fuel tank skid plate misbuilt**
  1989 · NHTSA 90V168000
- ☐ **Starter can engage without the key**
  1991–1993 · NHTSA 93V083000
- ☐ **Fuel sender gasket cracks**
  1987–1994 · NHTSA 94V106000
- ☐ **Parking brake can self-release (manual trans)**
  1990–1995 · NHTSA 02V041000
- ☐ **Front rotor corrosion (salt-belt states)**
  1990–1991 · NHTSA 98V005000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN, 1989–95**
  The 5th character is Y (Wrangler). The 6th is the trim: 1 is the base S, 4 Sahara, 5 Laredo, 6 Renegade. The 8th is the engine: E is the throttle-body 2.5 L four (1989–90), P the multi-point 2.5 L four (1991–95), S the 4.0 L six (1991–95), and M (1989) or T (1990) the 4.2 L six. NHTSA's decoder confirms the E, P and S codes.
- ☐ **VIN, 1987–88**
  Early trucks use the older AMC-style VIN, starting 2BC on the Brampton-built examples we decoded. The 4th character is the engine (C is the 4.2 L six; H the 2.5 L TBI four) and characters 6–7 read 81 for Wrangler.
- ☐ **Brampton or Toledo**
  In the NHTSA decoder, VINs starting with 2 decode to Brampton, Ontario, and VINs starting with 1J4 to Toledo, Ohio. Brampton built YJs until April 1992.
- ☐ **Renegade**
  Real Renegades were finished by Autostyle near Detroit and carry a small Autostyle sticker on the driver's door jamb above the latch. They came with the 4.0 six, 8-inch alloys, 30×9.50 tires, fender-mounted fog lights and the 20-gallon tank.
- ☐ **Engine and transfer case**
  A 4.0 L six means 1991 or later; a 4.2 means 1990 or earlier. The NP207 transfer case is 1987 only; everything after uses the NP231.

- [ ] **Late YJ details**
  1994–95 manual trucks have the external clutch slave cylinder (some 1993s may too). Some last-build 1995s got TJ-style hood bump stops, reinforced tailgate hinges and TJ rear bumpers.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/yj/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks